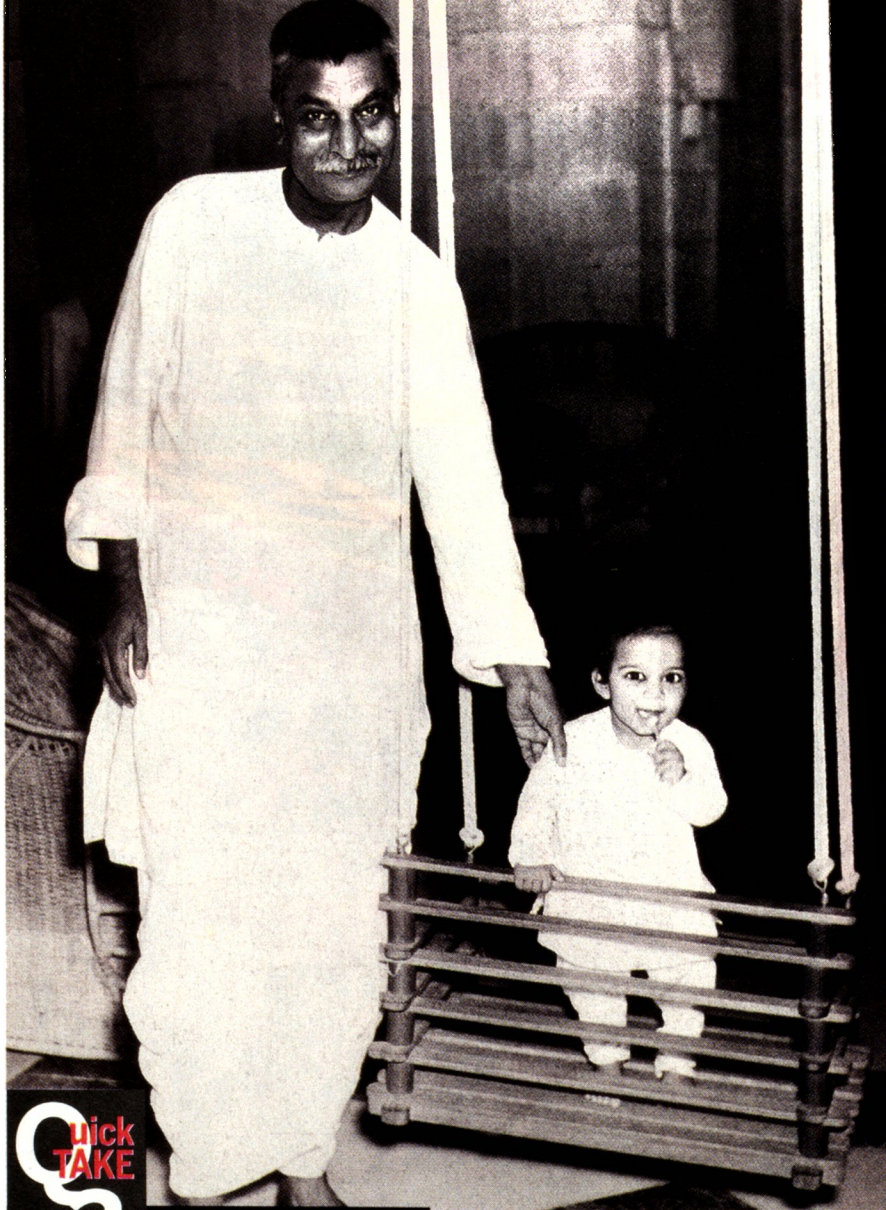


reach a point of split within the organisation and the movement. He imparted a crucial element of "compromise" to nationalist politics. This ensured that splits were avoided despite considerable plurality within the national movement. Since then these baseline-centred, consensus-seeking endeavours have become an important part of mainstream Indian politics. Prasad played an important role in inculcating these practices into India's body-politic.

As president of the Constituent Assembly, Prasad formed a team with Nehru and Maulana Azad in setting the basic principles of Constitution making. He declared at the very beginning that no major decision would be taken in the Assembly through a majority vote and nothing short of a unanimous voice would be accepted. This made it mandatory for the majority to reach out to minority voices and accommodate them. Till that happened, the decision would be kept pending. A consequence of this practice was an inordinate delay of over three years in finalising the Constitution. The delay notwithstanding, independent India got in 1950 a Constitution that all Indians can be proud of. Much of the credit for this should go to Prasad.

As the first President of Independent India, Prasad initiated many practices that subsequently became an unwritten rule or convention in Indian governance. One of these was to not unduly interfere in the business of the executive and the legislative arms of the central government. Prasad believed that the substantive status of the Indian President was, and should be, that of the British king, with powers more symbolic than real. He saw the role of President as the constitutional head who facilitates rather than initiates. During both his terms, Prasad saw to it that the office of President did not develop into an alternative centre of power, but functioned more as a vigilant and watchful institution. During the course of the national



HINDUSTAN TIMES



Q: Which leader's funeral did he attend against Nehru's advice?

A: Sardar Patel's funeral, 1950

Q: How many terms did he serve as President of India?

A: Two. He is the only president, so far, to have served a second term

Q: Where did Gandhi ask him to go after becoming food minister?

A: The sweeper's colony in Delhi

Q: For which commodity did he want tax to be abolished?

A: Salt

Q: Which national leader famously stayed away from his funeral?

A: Jawaharlal Nehru

movement there had been parity of power between Nehru and Prasad. But after Independence, Prasad fully recognised that it was Nehru, and not he, who was the chosen leader of the Indian people.

Prasad was, and remained all his life, a self-effacing, mild-mannered and socially-conservative leader. He always underplayed his own role in the major decisions of the day. The claims he made about himself never matched the actual, larger contributions he made. If we were to believe his own self-portrayal, as reflected in his autobiography and other writings, we would not be able to make an accurate assessment of him and miss out on the numerous ways in which Prasad enriched Indian politics.

The writer teaches history at Indira Gandhi National Open University, Delhi